

BUILD A BUSINESS THAT WORKS.

15 steps to start — and run — a business that looks legit, gets found, and books clients while you sleep. No fluff. Just the work that works.

More than *just* a website.

Anyone can put a business online.
Making it **work** — bringing in clients,
getting paid, running without you glued
to your phone — that's the game.

This guide walks you through all 15
steps in the exact order we'd do them
for you. Three phases. Zero fluff.

Build.

Steps 01-05

Get the foundation right: your strengths, your lane, your plan,
and a structure that won't crack when things take off.

Grow.

Steps 06-10

Look like the business you're meant to be. Brand, presence,
pricing, and marketing that turns strangers into booked clients.

Automate.

Steps 11-15

Run it like a pro. Systems for your time, your money, and your
growth — so the business works even when you're off the clock.

Build.

01

Know what you're great at

Your business starts with what you already do better than most people. What do folks compliment you on? What do they come to you for? That's not small talk — that's market research.

Do this

List 3 skills people pay for and 3 things you'd do for free. Your offer lives where those overlap.

02

Pick your lane

"Everyone" is not a target market. Decide exactly who you serve, what keeps them up at night, and why they'd pick you over the shop down the street. Specific wins. Every time.

Do this

Write one sentence: "I help [who] get [result] without [pain]." Tape it above your desk.

03

Sharpen your skills

You don't need another degree — you need to be a little better every month. Short courses, certifications, reps with real clients. Stay sharp and stay web-savvy while you're at it.

Do this

Block 2 hours a week for learning. Treat it like a client appointment — because future-you is the client.

Build the backbone.

04

Write the plan

A business plan isn't homework — it's your map. Get it on paper: goals for the year, how you'll measure success, and an honest forecast of what it costs to run and what it needs to earn.

Do this

One page is enough: goals, numbers to watch (your KPIs), and a simple cost-vs-earnings forecast.

05

Set up the structure

Structure isn't boring — it's freedom. Open a separate business bank account on day one. Talk to an accountant before tax season, not during. Get real contracts, not handshakes.

Do this

Business account, bookkeeping tool, one conversation with a tax pro. Three moves, endless headaches avoided.



You don't have to do everything alone. Outsource what drains you — that's not a luxury, it's how businesses actually scale.

Grow.

06

Nail your brand

Your brand is the promise people feel before they ever talk to you. Decide how you want to be seen, what story you're telling, and make every touchpoint match. Aesthetic matters — because trust is visual first.

Do this

Audit your logo, colors, and bio. If it doesn't look like a business you'd hire, fix it before you spend a dollar on ads.

07

Show up online

Your website is your best employee — it never sleeps, never misses a DM. Pair it with a social presence that shows your work, and clients can find you, trust you, and book you 24/7.

Do this

Make sure someone can find you, see your work, and take the next step in under 60 seconds.

08

Price with confidence

Package your services into clear offers with transparent pricing. Start somewhere, learn, adjust. And protect the work: contracts, policies, and a clean process every client goes through.

Do this

Build 2–3 named packages. Confused buyers don't buy — clear ones do.

Get seen. Get booked.

09

Market like you mean it

Marketing isn't shouting — it's showing up where your people already are. Content, email, and social that answer real questions build trust before the first call. A well-timed promo doesn't hurt either.

Do this

Pick two channels and own them. An email list you own beats an algorithm you rent.

10

Make clients love you

The booking is the beginning. Smooth onboarding, clear communication, and follow-through turn one-time clients into repeat clients — and repeat clients into referrals and five-star reviews.

Do this

Ask every happy client for a Google review. It's free marketing that compounds — and it boosts your search ranking too.



Stop losing customers to a missed DM. Every inquiry deserves an answer — even when you're with a client. (That's what automation is for.)

Automate.

11

Own your schedule

When you run the business, there's no off switch — unless you build one. Map your week: client work, marketing, admin, and actual rest. Protect the blocks like they're paying clients.

Do this

Use online booking so clients schedule themselves. Your calendar shouldn't need a middleman — especially not you at 11pm.

12

Track every dollar

Money you don't track is money you lose. Keep clean records of income and expenses, invoice digitally, and reconcile monthly. Tax season becomes a formality instead of a fire drill.

Do this

Budget for the unsexy stuff too: savings, taxes, ads, and upskilling. That's what pros do.

13

Keep learning

Stay humble, stay teachable. Trends shift, tools change, and the owners who keep learning stay booked. Client feedback is free coaching — actually use it.

Do this

After every project, ask one question: "What's one thing we could've done better?" Then do it better.

Run it like a pro.

14

Scale smart

Growth should feel exciting, not crushing. Hire help or outsource your blind spots, expand what's working, and keep a running list of your best ideas — collabs, new offers, big swings.

Do this

Write down every "aha" moment. Today's random idea is next quarter's best seller.

15

Evaluate & adjust

Working *on* your business matters as much as working *in* it. Check your numbers, your client happiness, and your own energy regularly. Double down on what works. Cut what doesn't.

Do this

Book a monthly 30-minute "CEO date" with yourself. Coffee, numbers, three decisions. That's it.

- *Success won't happen overnight. But with the right foundation and the right systems, it absolutely will happen.*

YOU MADE IT TO STEP 15. NOW LET'S MAKE IT REAL.

We don't just make it pretty. *We make it work.*

Brand, website, and AI automation for small businesses — built to book clients, answer every inquiry, and go live fast. Your business deserves more than just a website.

Start looking like the business you're meant to be

coastalunicorn.com